

Afternoon Discoveries

September 29, 2026



AMONG THE LETTERS

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Science Fiction & Fantasy

Several new science fiction and fantasy books arrive today, from Madeline Miller's compact return to Greek myth to Django Wexler's junkyard progression fantasy and Dan Warner's technological gothic. Away from the release calendar, older stories keep mutating into new shapes. Dale Bailey looks

beyond [The War of the Worlds](#), while Natalia Theodoridou lets ancient myth press into contemporary Athens, motorsport, clubs, and dating apps.

The result is an edition about what happens when a world hands someone a structure they did not choose: a war, a curse, an algorithm, a court, a master, a family story, or a mythology that has already decided who they are supposed to be.

All links in today's edition were checked against the linked magazine, publisher, author, or literary publication page on September 29, 2026.

Featured Discovery

After the Tripods - Dale Bailey

H. G. Wells ended *The War of the Worlds* with humanity surviving the Martians. Dale Bailey begins with the harder question: what does survival look like decades later?

In "After the Tripods," David survived the Martian attack as a child and later survived another war in France. Now he is raising his own son in a London where ruined fighting machines still stand over the city and the Martians' Red Blight continues spreading through the landscape.

Bailey does not treat the invasion as a finished catastrophe. The past remains visible in the geography, in David's memories, and in the fear that his son may inherit consequences he had no part in creating. That gives the story a second layer beyond its alternate history. It becomes a story about parenthood after disaster, and about the uncomfortable

fact that surviving something does not necessarily mean reaching its end.

Reactor published the 12,125-word novelette on September 23. It is free to read in full.

[Read "After the Tripods" at Reactor](#)

The Discovery Desk

Horse Boy - Natalia Theodoridou

Gus races cars, goes clubbing, uses Grindr, and lives in modern Athens. His body, however, remembers another life.

Natalia Theodoridou threads ancient Greek myth through a thoroughly contemporary existence without treating the present as a disguise draped over the past. The old stories survive in muscle memory, family relationships, unwanted transformations, ruins, desire, and the strange experience of becoming a person when other people already think they know the story you came from.

That tension gives "Horse Boy" an unusual energy. Myth is not distant material waiting to be retold. It is history the characters are still carrying in their bodies while they attempt to build lives that belong to them.

[Read "Horse Boy" at Uncanny Magazine](#)

Wither - Dan Warner

Regression can build a perfect digital twin from everything a person has left behind: data, secrets, mistakes, and the accumulated record of a life.

Mick once had the chance to test the technology in a remote Ozark town. A year after disappearing off the grid, he returns to Bloom, Missouri and finds cars in driveways, food left behind, and almost no people. He wants to find his girlfriend Alison and understand what happened. He also needs to find Regression before Regression finds him.

Dan Warner's debut places a familiar contemporary anxiety inside a gothic structure. The haunted thing is not an ancestral portrait or a locked room. It is the possibility that enough data can become a version of you, and that the version may not remain content to be an imitation.

[Read about *Wither* at Bloomsbury](#)

Mestra - Madeline Miller

Madeline Miller returns to Greek mythology with a much smaller book than *The Song of Achilles* or *Circe*, but the dilemma at its centre is immediately large.

Mestra, daughter of the King of Thessaly, has been given the ability to transform into any being she can imagine. Her father has received a very different gift from the gods, Demeter has cursed him with a hunger that can never be satisfied.

Mestra initially offers her power as a way to help him survive. The danger is contained in the obvious next question; if his need has no limit, how much of his daughter's life will he consume with it?

[Read about *Mestra* at Bloomsbury](#)

The Only Way Out Is Up - Django Wexler

Taj lives in a junkheap, scavenging scrap to help feed his family and trying to stay ahead of debt collectors. His best chance at changing that life is Star, a construct he built himself.

That chance becomes much larger when Taj is offered a place in the Ascent, an elite construct-fighting tournament with a prize capable of changing everything. The offer also carries the sort of danger that usually accompanies opportunities that look too good to be true.

Django Wexler's new novel mixes progression fantasy with robot fighting, but the person entering the grand competition begins at the literal bottom of the world around him.

Read about *The Only Way Out Is Up* at [Hachette Book Group](#)

Below this point are six more current science fiction and fantasy discoveries. There are also three pieces that go further into craft, worldbuilding, criticism, the stories behind the books, and three special recommendations worth returning to from the back shelf.

Thank you for supporting Among the Letters. Your support gives us the time to read beyond release lists, check each source, and to keep producing editions.

Special Recommendations can be found near the bottom of the article.

More From the Discovery Desk

Forged in FIYAH: Celebrating Ten Years of Black Speculative Fiction

Ten years of *FIYAH Magazine of Black Speculative Fiction* have produced an enormous range of futures, monsters, magic, histories, and imagined worlds. This anniversary anthology gathers eighteen stories to mark that decade.

The contributors include Maurice Broaddus, MH Ayinde, Tonja K Johnson, C. L. Clark, Suyi Davies Okungbowa, Tade Thompson, Eden Royce, Eboni Dunbar-Scott, Yvette Ndlovu, and others. The stories move across science fiction, fantasy, and horror, from magical healing silks and strange afterlives to killing machines, vampires, sinister dolls, and spaces between worlds.

An anniversary collection can easily become a monument to what has already happened. This one is more interesting as a map of how broad Black speculative fiction already is, and how many different directions its writers are pushing at once.

[Read about *Forged in FIYAH* at Macmillan](#)

The Court of Venus - Bel Banta

In Alvion, magic follows the planets.

Jupiter-born magicians influence luck. Saturn-born can speak with the dead. Venus-born can read desire. Bianca Mortlake is something much rarer though, the first Moonborn magician in more than a thousand years.

She has already escaped the royal court once when a summons drags her back into a world of executions, rival magicians, celestial power, and a monarchy where proximity to the throne can be dangerous in

itself. The person she may need most is Roland, the Venus-born rival she would prefer not to depend on.

[Read about *The Court of Venus* at Macmillan](#)

The House of Gardenias - Isabel Cañas

Minerva Treviño runs from a violent home and finds what initially looks like safety as a lady's maid.

Her new employer has money, warmth, food, political loyalties, and access to magical chispa. When a deposed viceroy returns to power, Minerva follows the household to the mountain estate known as la Casa de las Gardenias.

Isabel Cañas's young adult debut combines historical fantasy, gothic horror, political upheaval, and class tension. That makes it darker than much of today's fantasy shelf, but the book is still firmly interested in the machinery of power - who receives safety, who pays for it, and what an apparently protected house may be hiding.

[Read about *The House of Gardenias* at Penguin Random House](#)

Baldur's Gate 3: Astarion - T. Kingfisher

Before the events of *Baldur's Gate 3*, Astarion was already looking for a way out.

T. Kingfisher's new novel follows him while he is still trapped in servitude to the vampire lord Cazador Szarr. When Cazador announces a competition and a rare prize appears within reach, Astarion sees an opening that may allow him to act for himself rather than for his master.

Getting there requires an alliance with Hahn den Suriel, an Aasimar paladin, and several acts Astarion has specifically not been permitted to make.

The book is a prequel rather than a retelling of the game, which gives Kingfisher room to work inside the period when Astarion's desire for freedom existed without any guarantee that freedom was possible.

[Read about *Baldur's Gate 3: Astarion* at Penguin Random House](#)

Threshing Day - Rebecca Yarros

Threshing Day returns to Basgiath through thirteen stories rather than another single continuous novel.

Rebecca Yarros's new Empyrean collection focuses on one legendary day in the brutal world of a military college for dragon riders. The format makes room for different characters, relationships, dangers, and corners of a setting that has grown well beyond the perspective of any one rider.

A story collection is an interesting choice for an established fantasy world. Instead of extending the central plot in a straight line, it can widen the field and let secondary lives carry narrative weight of their own.

[Read about *Threshing Day* on Rebecca Yarros's official site](#)

The Lost Spectacular - Zoé Duhaime

Noon Bonaventure and Munro Forrest grew up loving the same stories. Eventually, they became rivals inside one.

At the centre of Zoé Duhaime's debut is the Spectacular, a mysterious travelling festival filled with things that have been lost. Noon and Munro encounter it when they are young, then spend years taking very different approaches to what it means to lose something.

By adulthood Munro wants to capture the Spectacular for a museum exhibition while Noon has been chosen as its next captain. Their pursuit moves through stories, books, paintings, private letters, family history, and grief.

[Read about *The Lost Spectacular* at Penguin Random House](#)

Beyond the First Shelf

Introducing My Next Novel: **The House of Gardenias - Isabel Cañas**

The most useful companion to *The House of Gardenias* comes directly from Isabel Cañas.

In February, Cañas described the book as the novel that remained closest to its original story seed. That seed was a 2020 nightmare about a young woman in a haunted house who befriends a somewhat monstrous ghost. The plot took years to build around it, but the central image survived through drafting, revision, and the long path to publication.

That makes the piece worth reading as more than a cover reveal. It is a compact look at how a novel can change enormously while one stubborn image continues to tell the writer what the book wants to become.

[Read Isabel Cañas's newsletter](#)

Sanderson, Fantasylands, and the Subversive Geography of Roshar - Jayden King

A fantasy map can quietly decide much more than where the mountains go.

Jayden King's new Reactor essay looks at the familiar pseudo-medieval landscapes that have become default settings for a great deal of fantasy and then asks what changes when a writer refuses that default. The focus is Brandon Sanderson's Roshar, a world whose storms, ecology, geography, and built environments force its societies to develop around conditions very different from a softened version of medieval Europe.

The useful part of the essay is the connection between geography and story logic. Worldbuilding becomes more convincing when landscape is not decoration placed behind a culture, but one of the forces that helped create the culture in the first place.

[Read the essay at Reactor](#)

Pulling Down The Gods From Heaven: Jesse Aragon's *The Demon Star* - Sasha Bonkowsky

What happens to a fantasy world when its gods are not metaphors, but physical beings whose power can apparently be challenged?

Sasha Bonkowsky's review of Jesse Aragon's *The Demon Star* begins on Celes Lor, a brutal world ruled under the shadow of divine beings associated with despair, sickness, pain, fear, sorrow, and hunger. The

discovery that one of those gods may have been killed opens a larger question about faith, authority, sacrifice, and what separates a god from any other creature powerful enough to demand obedience.

The review is also useful because it does not flatten criticism into recommendation. Bonkowsky considers what the book's gritty science-fantasy world does effectively while also identifying places where repeated dramatic language can become less precise than the ideas deserve.

[Read the review at Reactor](#)

Special Recommendations

Seasons of Glass and Iron - Amal El-Mohtar

Two women from two different fairy-tale problems meet where neither story expects them to.

Tabitha must wear down seven pairs of iron shoes. Amira sits atop a glass mountain. Both situations come from old tale-types in which a woman's suffering is treated as part of the machinery required to reach an ending.

Instead of asking how faithfully each woman can endure the role assigned to her, "Seasons of Glass and Iron" asks what becomes possible once someone else looks at that role and says it should never have been required in the first place.

It remains one of the more elegant examples of fairy-tale revision because it does not discard the old machinery. It turns the machinery around and examines what it was doing.

Read “Seasons of Glass and Iron” at [Uncanny Magazine](#)

The City Born Great - N. K. Jemisin

In N. K. Jemisin’s New York, becoming a great city is not a metaphor.

When a metropolis grows large and old enough, it must be born as something more than streets and buildings. That birth also attracts ancient enemies that would prefer the new life never arrive.

The person caught in the middle is an unlikely midwife who has to learn how to hear, sing, and finally embody the city around him.

Originally published in 2016 and later used as a foundation for Jemisin’s Great Cities novels, the story still stands comfortably on its own. It is urban fantasy in the most literal possible sense, the city is not merely the setting...

Read “The City Born Great” at [Reactor](#)

A Dream of Electric Mothers - Wole Talabi

A government facing a border dispute decides to ask its ancestors for advice.

The complication is that the ancestors are now a collective technological intelligence known as the electric mother.

Wole Talabi’s novelette places futuristic computation beside Yoruba-influenced ritual and political decision-making, then lets the difficult question emerge naturally; if a system can speak with the apparent authority of history, how certain can its users be that the answer they receive is genuinely what the past would have told them?

The story was first published in *Africa Risen* and later reprinted free by Reactor. Its technology is speculative, but the problem is old. Political leaders have always wanted the past to authorize the decisions they are already considering.

Read "A Dream of Electric Mothers" at Reactor

Thank you for spending part of your day among the letters with us.

Today's discoveries move from Martian ruins and ancient transformations to hungry algorithms, celestial magic, dragon riders, digital doubles, haunted houses, and gods that may be less untouchable than they appear.

The surfaces change quickly, but a quieter question keeps appearing underneath them: how much of a life is inherited, and how much can still be remade?

Science fiction and fantasy are particularly good at making that question visible. They can turn inheritance into a curse, a ruined planet, a machine, a god's gift, a body, or an entire story that insists it already knows how you end.

Take care!

✓ **Subscribed**